

The Difficulty Senior High School Students Face in Choosing College Courses and Its Impact on Decision Certainty

CHAPTER I

THE PROBLEM AND ITS BACKGROUND

1. Introduction

Choosing a college course is one of the most important decisions that senior high school students must make before entering higher education. This decision often determines the academic path that students will follow and may influence their future career opportunities. However, many students experience difficulty when selecting a course because they are still exploring their interests, abilities, and long-term goals. At the senior high school level, students are often required to decide on a college program even when they are not yet fully certain about what they want to pursue. Because of this situation, the process of choosing a course can become stressful and confusing, especially for students who lack sufficient guidance or information about different career options.

Career decision-making is a complex process that involves evaluating personal interests, abilities, values, and external influences. According to Li and He (2025), many students experience career decision-making difficulties due to limited information about possible career paths and uncertainty about their own capabilities. When students do not clearly understand their strengths or future goals, they may feel overwhelmed when choosing a college course. This uncertainty can lead to hesitation and doubt, making it harder for them to make confident decisions about their academic future. As a result, students may delay their decisions or rely heavily on external opinions rather than their own interests.

Several factors contribute to the challenges that students encounter when selecting their college programs. These factors may include family expectations, peer influence, financial considerations, and perceived job opportunities. Research conducted by Kim and Lee (2022) suggests that students who have lower levels of career decision-making self-efficacy often struggle more with choosing a suitable academic program. When students lack confidence in their ability to make career-related decisions, they may become uncertain about which course best fits their skills and interests. This lack of confidence may further complicate the decision-making process, especially when students are faced with numerous program choices in higher education institutions.

In addition to personal factors, social and environmental influences also play a significant role in students' career decisions. Yaghi and Alabed (2021) explained that students' career choices are often affected by their family background, employment expectations, and social environment. Some students may choose a course because it is recommended by parents or relatives rather than because it matches their own interests. While these influences may provide guidance, they may also create pressure that leads to uncertainty and confusion in decision-making. When students feel pressured to choose a certain program, they may struggle to determine whether the decision truly reflects their own aspirations.

Another important aspect related to course selection is career indecision. Career indecision occurs when students are unable to confidently choose a specific career or academic path. Dwatra and Adri (2021) found that many high school students experience career indecision due to insufficient knowledge about available academic fields and the skills required for certain professions. When students are unsure about their future career direction, they may find it difficult to identify the college course that aligns with their goals. This situation can increase anxiety and uncertainty during the transition from senior high school to higher education.

Furthermore, difficulties in career decision-making may also affect students' confidence in their chosen path. Simanjuntak, Cahyono, and Rohinsa (2024) emphasized that exploring career options alone is not always enough for students to make confident decisions. Without proper guidance, students may still feel uncertain even after considering different possibilities. Decision uncertainty can lead to future challenges such as dissatisfaction with their chosen program or even shifting courses during college. Therefore, understanding the factors that contribute to students' difficulties in choosing college courses is important in order to provide better support and guidance during this critical stage of decision-making.

This study aims to examine the difficulties that senior high school students face when choosing college courses and to determine how these difficulties influence their level of decision certainty. By identifying the challenges encountered by students during the course selection process, the study seeks to provide insights that may help educators, guidance counselors, and students themselves develop strategies to support more confident and informed academic decisions.

1.2 Significance of the Study

Senior High School Students. This study may help students understand the different factors that influence their decisions when choosing college courses and encourage them to make more informed and confident choices regarding their future academic paths.

Guidance Counselors. The findings of this study may help guidance counselors better understand the challenges students face in choosing college courses and allow them to design more effective career guidance programs.

Teachers. This study may provide teachers with insights about the difficulties experienced by students in making career-related decisions, enabling them to offer better academic and career support.

Parents. The results of the study may help parents understand the challenges their children experience when selecting college courses and encourage them to provide appropriate guidance and support.

School Administrators. This study may help school administrators develop programs, seminars, or career orientation activities that assist students in making better educational decisions.

Future Researchers. The study may serve as a reference for future researchers who plan to conduct related studies about career decision-making and course selection among students.

Educational Institutions. The findings may help educational institutions improve their career guidance services and provide better information about academic programs available to students.

1.3 Theoretical Framework

Career Decision-Making Theory

This study is anchored on the Career Decision-Making Theory developed by Samuel H. Osipow, which explains the difficulties individuals experience when making career-related decisions. The theory emphasizes that choosing a career path is a complex process that involves evaluating personal interests, abilities, available opportunities, and external influences. According to this theory, individuals may encounter career decision-making difficulties when they lack sufficient information, experience uncertainty about their

interests and abilities, or feel pressure from external sources such as family or peers. For senior high school students, selecting a college course represents one of the earliest major career decisions they must make. Because students are still developing their self-awareness and understanding of different career opportunities, they may struggle to determine which course best aligns with their skills and future goals. Studies in recent years have also emphasized that career decision-making difficulties are common among adolescents who are transitioning from secondary education to higher education, particularly when they are faced with multiple academic choices and limited career guidance (Kim & Lee, 2022).

The theory further explains that career indecision often results from several categories of difficulties, including lack of readiness, lack of information, and inconsistent information during the decision-making process. Lack of readiness may occur when students are not yet prepared to make long-term career decisions, while lack of information may arise when students do not have adequate knowledge about academic programs, career requirements, or job opportunities. Inconsistent information, on the other hand, may occur when students receive conflicting advice from parents, teachers, or peers regarding which course to pursue. These factors can significantly influence the level of certainty students feel about their decisions. Recent research supports this perspective by highlighting that students who have limited access to career information and guidance are more likely to experience uncertainty and anxiety when choosing academic programs (Simanjuntak, Cahyono, & Rohinsa, 2024). Similarly, studies have shown that students with lower levels of career decision-making self-efficacy tend to experience greater difficulty in selecting courses because they doubt their ability to make appropriate career choices (Li & He, 2025).

In relation to the present study, the Career Decision-Making Theory provides a useful framework for understanding the difficulties that senior high school students encounter when choosing their college courses and how these difficulties may influence their level of decision certainty. The theory suggests that when students face challenges such as lack of information, external pressure, or uncertainty about their personal interests and abilities, their confidence in making career decisions may decrease. This may result in hesitation, indecision, or reliance on external opinions rather than personal preferences. Previous research has also demonstrated that students who experience greater decision-making difficulties tend to show lower levels of confidence and certainty in their chosen academic paths (Yaghi & Alabed, 2021). Therefore, this theory supports the assumption that the challenges encountered by senior high school students during the course selection process may significantly influence how certain they feel about their decisions regarding their future education and careers.

1.4 Conceptual Framework

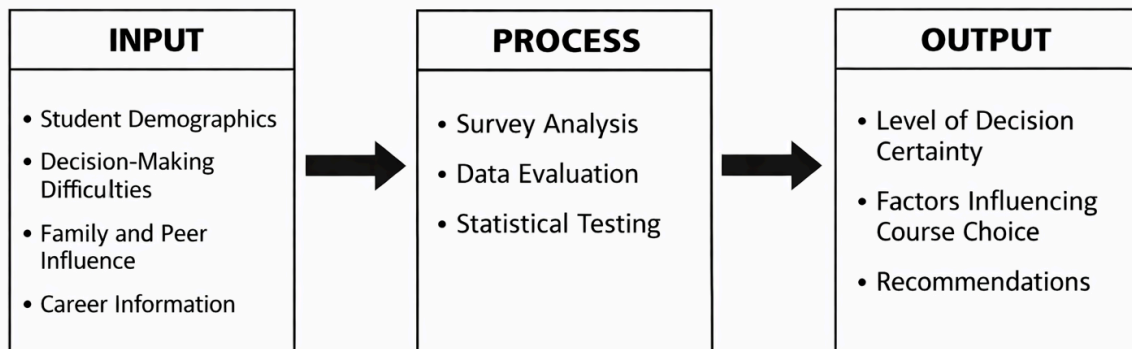


Figure 1. IPO Model

This section presents the conceptual framework of the study which illustrates the relationship between the variables involved in the research. The framework is based on the Input–Process–Output (IPO) model, which is commonly used in quantitative research to explain how certain inputs are processed to produce specific outcomes. In this study, the IPO model is used to describe how the different factors affecting students’ difficulty in choosing college courses are examined and analyzed to determine their influence on students’ level of decision certainty. The framework helps clarify how the variables are connected and how the research process leads to the findings of the study.

In the Input stage, the study considers the demographic profile of the respondents such as age, gender, academic strand, and academic performance. It also includes the different factors that may contribute to students’ difficulty in choosing college courses, such as personal interests and abilities, availability of career information, family influence, peer influence, and financial considerations. These variables serve as the primary inputs of the study because they represent the conditions and characteristics that may affect students’ decision-making process regarding their future academic paths.

The Process stage refers to the procedures used by the researchers to gather and analyze the data. This includes the distribution of survey questionnaires to senior high school students, the collection of responses, and the statistical analysis of the gathered data. The researchers will organize, interpret, and evaluate the data in order to determine the level of difficulty experienced by students in choosing college courses and their level of decision certainty. Through these processes, the relationship between the variables will be examined to determine whether the difficulties encountered by students significantly influence their confidence in selecting a college program.

Finally, the Output stage represents the results or outcomes of the study. The output includes the identified level of difficulty experienced by senior high school students in choosing college courses and their level of decision certainty regarding their chosen programs. The findings may also provide insights into the factors that significantly influence students' decision-making processes. These results can serve as a basis for recommendations that may help educators, guidance counselors, and students improve the process of career and course selection in the future.

1.5 Statement of the Problem

Choosing a college course is an important decision for senior high school students as it can influence their future education and career paths. However, many students experience difficulty when deciding which course to pursue due to various personal, academic, and external factors. These difficulties may include lack of information about career options, uncertainty about personal interests and abilities, and influence from family or peers. As a result, some students may feel unsure or less confident about their chosen course, which can affect their level of decision certainty. Understanding the difficulties that students face when selecting college courses is essential in identifying the factors that contribute to their uncertainty and decision-making process.

This study aims to examine the difficulties senior high school students face in choosing college courses and determine how these difficulties affect their level of decision certainty.

Specifically, this study seeks to answer the following research questions:

1. What are the demographic profiles of the senior high school students in terms of:
 - 1.1 Age
 - 1.2 Gender
 - 1.3 Academic Strand
 - 1.4 Academic Performance
2. What is the level of difficulty experienced by senior high school students in choosing college courses in terms of:
 - 2.1 Personal Interests and Abilities
 - 2.2 Availability of Career Information
 - 2.3 Family Influence
 - 2.4 Peer Influence
 - 2.5 Financial Considerations
3. What is the level of decision certainty among senior high school students in choosing their college courses?

4. Is there a significant relationship between the difficulties faced by senior high school students in choosing college courses and their level of decision certainty?
5. Is there a significant difference in the level of decision certainty when students are grouped according to their demographic profile?

1.6 Hypothesis of the Study

H_0 (Null Hypothesis). There is no significant relationship between the difficulties senior high school students face in choosing college courses and their level of decision certainty.

H_1 (Alternative Hypothesis). There is a significant relationship between the difficulties senior high school students face in choosing college courses and their level of decision certainty.

1.7 Scope and Delimitations

This study focuses on identifying the difficulties that senior high school students encounter when choosing their college courses and determining how these difficulties affect their level of decision certainty. The research specifically examines selected factors that may influence students' decision-making process, including personal interests and abilities, availability of career information, family influence, peer influence, and financial considerations. In addition, the study also considers the demographic profile of the respondents such as age, gender, academic strand, and academic performance. Through a quantitative approach, the study will gather data from senior high school students using a structured survey questionnaire to measure the level of difficulty they experience in choosing college courses and their level of certainty in making their decisions.

However, this study has certain delimitations that define its boundaries. The research is limited only to selected senior high school students and does not include college students or students from other educational levels. The data will be collected solely through self-reported survey responses, which means the results will depend on the honesty and accuracy of the participants' answers. Additionally, the study focuses only on specific factors that may influence course selection and does not cover other possible influences such as cultural background, personality traits, or institutional policies. The findings of this study will therefore apply only to the selected respondents and may not fully represent all senior high school students in different schools or regions.

1.8 Definition of Terms

Career Decision-Making. The process of selecting a future career path based on an individual's interests, abilities, values, and available opportunities.

College Course. A specific academic program or field of study that students choose to pursue in higher education.

Decision Certainty. The level of confidence or assurance a student has regarding their chosen college course or career path.

Difficulty in Course Selection. The challenges or obstacles that students experience when deciding which college program to pursue.

Family Influence. The impact of parents or relatives on a student's decision when selecting a college course.

Peer Influence. The effect that friends or classmates may have on a student's choice of college course.

Senior High School Students. Learners who are currently enrolled in Grades 11 and 12 under the K-12 educational system.

Career Information. Knowledge or guidance about different academic programs, career opportunities, and job requirements that helps students make educational decisions.

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